

Resurgence of Wood in Contemporary Nigerian Sculpture

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Abstract

This study explores the resurgence of wood as a major material in contemporary Nigerian sculpture, with particular emphasis on its reconstituted relevance in the country's changing visual arts scene. Although wood was historically intrinsic to Nigerian sculptural traditions used in both ritual and everyday contexts, its use declined in the postcolonial era with the introduction of modernization and synthetic materials. In recent times, however, Nigerian contemporary artists have begun to reclaim and redefine wood, perceiving it not merely as a cultural relic but also as a vehicle for conceptual inquiry. The research explores how some artists engage with wood to address matters of identity, memory, postcolonial critique, environmentalism, and cultural continuity. Consideration is given to materiality and sustainability, as wood (particularly reclaimed varieties) aligns with current ecological and haptic sensibilities in globalized art discourse. Through art historical research, interviews, and field observations, this project investigates how artists combine traditional techniques with modern forms and meanings. Ultimately, the return to wood represents a deep engagement with indigenous knowledge and artistic autonomy, thus rendering it a medium of resistance and transformation, rather than nostalgia. This resurgence represents a key shift in Nigerian sculpture; wherein material choice is used as a means of intervening in Africa's placement in global contemporary art discourses.

Keywords: Materiality, Postcolonial Art, Indigenous Knowledge, Sustainability, Nigerian Sculpture

Introduction

Wood has traditionally held a central place in African sculptural traditions, particularly in Nigeria, where societies like the Yoruba, Igbo, and Benin evolved highly complex and symbolic wood-carving practices. These were not simply aesthetic traditions but were inextricably linked with ritual, religion, kingship, and social identity. Wood sculptures had varied functions: from ancestral figures and shrine objects to ceremonial masks and everyday tools, all of which were frequently imbued with sacred and cultural meaning (Abiodun, 2014). In precolonial societies, wood was not just material; it was a

living material that was seen to harbour spiritual energy or *ase*, particularly among the Yoruba (Drewal, 2019). Wood, then, had both symbolic and functional agency, mediating the physical and metaphysical realms.

The advent of colonial rule and the eventual introduction of Western-style art education in Nigeria, particularly through schools like the Nigerian College of Arts, Science and Technology and the Zaria Art School, caused a dwindling of wood's visibility as a medium. Postcolonial modernism in the mid-20th century accelerated the turn to new materials and aesthetics that emphasized formal innovation and global appeal (Ogbechie, 2015; Adelaja, 2021). Artists like Ben Enwonwu, Uche Okeke, and Bruce Onobrakpeya, as grounded as they were in African tradition, often distanced themselves from traditional methods and materials, including wood, in favour of bronze casting, linocut, or abstract painting. This signalled a profound ideological shift in Nigerian art and a move towards "modern" expression that, paradoxically, sometimes entailed the denial of indigenous material culture to gain acceptance in global art circles (Onwuegbule, 2021).

In subsequent decades, particularly from the 1970s until the early 2000s, wood became increasingly peripheral in mainstream modern Nigerian sculpture. Although some sculptors persisted with its use, the medium was commonly equated with either ethnographic or craft practice, rather than high modern art. The prevalence of metal, cement, plastics, and mixed media installations mirrored larger shifts in international art discourse, which favoured innovation, conceptuality, and hybridity over material continuity (Ikpakronyi, 2016). Institutional and environmental factors, including the lack of support for traditional carving and deforestation issues, also accounted for the dwindling of wood's visibility in studio practice.

Over the past two decades, there has been a renewed interest in wood among Nigerian sculptors and mixed-media artists. This revival is more than the mere re-awakening of past traditions; it involves a deep re-contextualization of wood as a modern material capable of engaging pressing cultural, environmental, and political concerns. Gerald Chukwuma, Ndidi Dike, Amarachi Okafor, and Joshua Nmesirionye (Plates 1 - 5) are among the artists that have gone back to wood to engage with such issues as identity, postcolonial memory, environmental degradation, and social change

(Adebayo, 2018; Okafor, 2022). This turn in art is coincident with global contemporary art trends that underscore materiality, sustainability, and decolonization, as well as engaging localized histories and indigenous knowledges.

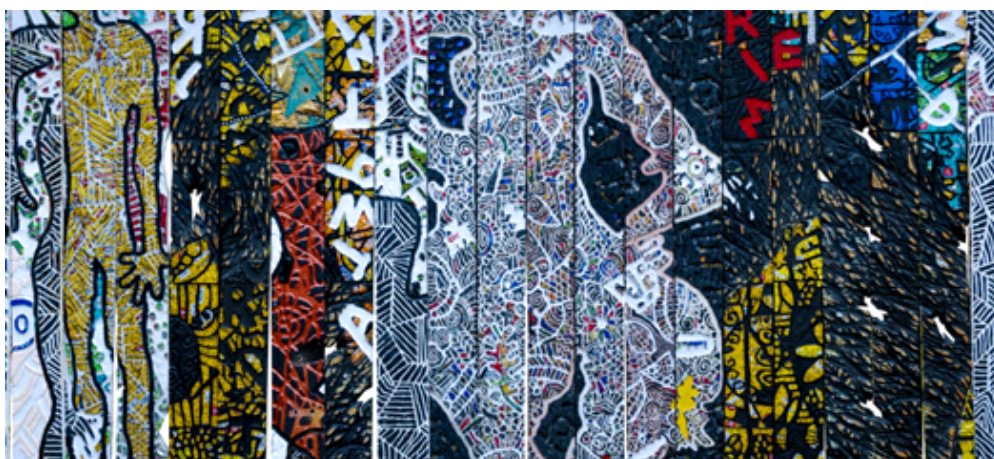


Plate 1: Gerald Chukwuma Elewe Ukwu; And Women Dominate the World, 2019 Mixed Media. 78 × 117 in | 198.1 × 297.2 cm.
<https://www.artsy.net/artwork/gerald-chukwuma-eternity>



Plate 2: Eternity, circa 2016 Wood. 78 × 50 × 1 1/5 in | 198 × 127 × 3 cm
<https://www.artsy.net/artwork/gerald-chukwuma-eternity>



Plate 3: A-ARTs: Nmesirionye's Symphony of boundless lines at Yenwa Gallery



Plate 4:
Joshua Nmesirionye | Sisterhood I
(2018) <https://www.yenwagallery.com/>



Plate 5:
Joshua Nmesirionye. Nigerian, b.
1968 <https://www.yenwagallery.com/>

Gerald Chukwuma, for example, uses burnt and incised wooden panels, layered with paint and aluminium, to tell the tales of Igbo migration and resilience, thereby fusing visual language with oral history. His creative projects defy the traditional linear difference between the old and the new forms, placing wood as a malleable material for cultural narrative (Adebayo, 2018). Similarly, works with discarded wood scraps in her installations that

broach questions of gender identity, societal rot, and communal healing. Her creative process not only re-uses a material once considered waste but also reinvests it with new conceptual meaning that is firmly grounded in social critique (Okafor, 2022). Nnidi Dike (Plate 6, 7) utilizes her imagination talent to address and engage with such serious subjects as colonialism and slavery, as well as historical and current impact of the Trans-Atlantic slave trade. She employs mixed-media and research that has been conducted over periods of months to create her pieces. This has also been extended to related topics such as that of value, of material and human life, that she has recently made pieces to display about. The topics that she writes about for each of her pieces determine the mixed-media items that she chooses to add into a piece.

The fascination of Dike with such topics is understandably related to her Nigerian heritage, even though she was born in London. She emphasizes the way that centuries of oppression and repressive ideology have brought about misunderstanding and war on the African continent by way of issues of economy, the social world, or politics. She also addresses issues like gender inequality and patriarchy. Her work in the Nigerian contemporary art arena has been described as being markedly different due to the manner in which she has blended traditionally applied elements of African art with contemporary methods.



Plate 6: [MAHOGANY MULTI MEDIA CLOTH](#), 2001 Mixed media [Sculpture](#)
76 x 74 cm. (30 x 29½ in.)
<https://www.mutualart.com/Artwork/UNTITLED/B8BC4CF1D9B13391A2E6F526EAAC2C63>



Plate 7: [UNTITLED](#). Wood [Sculpture](#) 134.5 x 22⁷/₈ in.)

<https://www.mutualart.com/Artwork/UNTITLED/B8BC4CF1D9B13391A2E6F526EAAC2C63>

The contemporary resurgence of wood is also led by broader discussions around sustainability and environmentalism. With rising global concern over climate change and the degradation of natural resources, artists are ever more drawn to organic, biodegradable materials such as wood that are in such stark contrast with synthetic and industrial materials of previous decades (Adeyemi, 2019). In this context, wood is not only considered for its historical and cultural poignancy but also its environmental relevance. Nigerian sculptors then are working within an emergent global eco-aesthetic that seeks to balance material practice and moral imperative (Mokgosi and Enwezor, 2017). Thus, the turn back to wood is also a deeper epistemological shift in African art. Scholars and artists are breaking centuries of hierarchies that situated indigenous African media and procedures as second best or archaic in relation to Western standards. Through their work in wood, Nigerian artists now are asserting control over material and process, carrying out what Onwuegbule (2021) has described as "critical indigenism", a strategy of using indigenous forms to challenge modernity instead of merely preserving heritage. This is in line with the endeavour of decolonizing art practice, material and idea, and revitalizing the stories implicit in local art tradition.

The resurgence of wood in Nigerian sculpture also raises pedagogic and institutional challenges. Nigerian universities and art schools are beginning to

reengineer curricula that hitherto inclined toward European modernism, including courses in local technology, traditional carving, and green art. It is a pedagogic rebalancing that helps young artists to look at wood not as something of the past, but as a material of world-making (Aniakor, 2020). Besides, galleries, biennales, and residencies now increasingly provide platforms for wood sculptors to capture wider appeal for its versatility and pertinence. The renewed interest in wood as a medium in Nigerian sculpture in recent times is investigated in this work with all the sophistication of such evolution, aesthetic to ideological, environmental, and political.

By means of case studies of prominent artists and close readings of individual pieces, this project examines how wood is employed by artists to address contentious topics such as cultural identity, historical trauma, and ecological awareness. Based on art historical research, interviews, and ethnographic fieldwork, the project reads how wood is a site of tension and experimentation within the postcolonial Nigerian context. Lastly, the re-discovery of wood should not be interpreted as a nostalgic compromise with tradition but as a radical re-appreciation of what historic materials can do in modern times. The wood revolution is symptomatic of the desire to place artistic practice within local epistemologies and being sensitive to global discourse. It is thus a turning point in Nigerian sculpture, a point at which material usage is not technically but very ideologically driven, a resistance, recovery, and redefinition.

Methodology

The study follows a qualitative, practice-informed art historical methodology, integrating studio-based research, semi-structured interviews, and ethnographic field observation in its exploration of the resurgence of wood as an important sculptural material in contemporary Nigerian art. The methodology is located in the wider discourse of practice-as-research in the creative arts, which privileges knowledge production through material engagement, critical reflection, and embedded cultural practices (Barrett and Bolt, 2010). Due to the priority of material and conceptual operations in sculpture, the research draws upon firsthand experience of artists' work, studio operations, and interpretive models in excavating the different meanings and socio-political implications of wood use today. Fieldwork was undertaken through visiting art exhibitions, galleries, and studios in Lagos, Abuja, and Enugu, where wood is used as a main material by a few contemporary Nigerian

sculptors namely Gerald Chukwuma, Ndidi dike, Amarachi Okafor, and Joshua Nmesirionye. Participant observation of open studios, and photographing works-in-progress, allowed for closer knowledge of how these artists navigate through material choice, cultural memory, environmental sustainability, and postcolonial identity in their sculptural practice.

The artists, curators, and art historians were asked in-depth questions regarding why they work with wood, the symbolic and aesthetic potential of wood, and political meanings. The interviews were tape-recorded and transcribed and coded thematically according to qualitative content analysis procedures. The method is consistent with Biggs and Büchler's (2008) focus on contextual and reflective standards of judging creative practices as valid knowledge production sites. Apart from this, this study is guided by critical decolonial theories, specifically African theorists who stress the need for reclamation of indigenous materials and symbolic languages in modern cultural production (Nhemachena, 2017). This strand of thinking is guided by the concept of "epistemic disobedience" (Nkosinkulu, 2023) insofar as it interrogates the Eurocentric hierarchies that historically disempowered African materials such as wood for Western models of artistic modernity. By integrating field-based evidence and piercing analysis of materiality, symbolism, and socio-cultural context, this approach brings to the fore the wood's active role as not just a medium for sculpture but as an agent of decolonial knowledge, ecological ethics, and cultural resilience. Triangulating studio practice, oral testimony, and contextual critique gives a solid methodological grounding for explaining the ideological re-emergence of wood in Nigerian contemporary sculpture.

Contextual Background: Traditional and Postcolonial Shifts

Wood was also religious, ritualistic, and culturally significant to Nigerian art for centuries. It was not merely an aesthetic transmission but a source of spiritual power and collective identity previously. In Yoruba, Igbo, and Benin cultures, woodcarvings were utilized during ceremonies, shrines, and social rankings, functioning within broader cosmological and ancestral belief systems (Drewal, 2019; Abiodun, 2014). In all these situations, wood was interpreted as a medium by which spiritual energy and cultural memory were embodied.

The independence period of the 1960s saw a fantastic development in

Nigeria's art scene. Artists schooled in formal institutions, such as the Zaria Art School, began exploring themes associated with nationalism and modernism. These artists, who became known as the "Zaria Rebels," advocated for the Natural Synthesis ideology, which entailed the synthesis of indigenous artistic principles and modern methods (Adelaja, 2021). Despite this ideological synthesis, many artists increasingly abandoned conventional materials, like wood, and instead opted to work with metal, concrete, fiberglass, and other industrial materials that were informed by Western modernist perspectives (Ogbechie, 2015; Onwuegbule, 2021). This move added to a conceptual break in material perception. Wood became identified with the past, tradition, or "craft," whereas new materials represented progress, innovation, and global relevance. In galleries, biennials, and art academies, wooden sculpture tended to be excluded or marginalized in favour of installation art, assemblage, and digital media (Ikpakronyi, 2016; Adeyemi, 2019). Wood, therefore, came to be perceived increasingly in nostalgic or ethnographic terms rather than as a possible medium for contemporary expression. However, this historical marginalization laid the groundwork for its present revival—one characterized by ideological reassessment, environmental concern, and the reclamation of indigenous epistemologies in the 21st century.

Modern Revival and Artistic Approaches

The wood renaissance in modern Nigerian sculpture is a material and conceptual realignment of tremendous importance, occasioned to a great extent by a new generation of artists who are bent on repossessing indigenous materials as essential tools for narrative engagement, advocacy, and culture reflection. It should not be misconstrued as a straightforward revival of things past; rather, it is a tactical manoeuvre that retheorizes wood as subversive and dynamic material strongly suited to convey issues of decolonization, environmentalism, gender dynamics, and postcolonial memory (Onwuegbule, 2021; Adeyemi, 2019). Prominent among such artists is Gerald Chukwuma, whose sculptural installations created with burned, carved, and painted wood reimagine Igbo migration histories and cosmological thought. His practice fuses traditional design motifs with street art and contemporary urban narratives, creating a visual vocabulary that brokers indigenous heritage and global modern aesthetics (Adebayo, 2018). Chukwuma's layered surfaces, often coated in nsibidi-like markings, offer a tactile archive of resistance, memory, and transformation.

Similarly, Amarachi Okafor uses reclaimed wood in mixed-media installations that confront gender, religion, and communal trauma. Her practice combines sculptural structures with text, cloth, and performance, yielding works that are intensely personal and yet socially engaged. Through her use of abandoned wood, Okafor not only underscores sustainability but also critiques systems of abandonment and exclusion, highlighting what is discarded materially and socially (Okafor, 2022). New talents such as Joshua Nmesirionye investigate wood's expressive potential through the fusion of figuration and abstraction, utilizing chiselling, burning, and assemblage to tell stories of urban dislocation and cultural hybridity. These artistic approaches trouble the idea of wood as a fixed, "authentic" artifact of the past, reinscribing it instead as an active agent in present-day political and environmental debate (Aniakor, 2020). In these practices, wood is reimagined from cultural artifact to living medium of innovation, resilience, and critical engagement.

Materiality, Sustainability, and Environmental Awareness

The reinvigorated use of wood in contemporary Nigerian sculpture marks an urgent shift towards environmental sustainability and ethical sourcing of materials. As we live in a time increasingly defined by the climate crisis, environmental degradation, and rampant industrialization, artists are rethinking their material choices. Wood, especially when reclaimed, repurposed, or sourced responsibly, offers an alternative that is not only environmentally sustainable but also rich in cultural symbolism (Okeke-Agulu, 2015). Its organic qualities are a stark contrast to the ubiquity of synthetic and non-biodegradable materials that have traditionally dominated the global art market.

Nigerian artists today celebrate these material predicaments by adopting wood not only for its beauty or historical significance, but for what it means ecologically. Through the utilization of waste wood offcuts or trees that have fallen naturally, such artists point toward a practice of reuse and recuperation. Such an ethos of sustainability can be seen in the work of artists such as Amarachi Okafor, whose installations quite literally bring to the forefront questions of environmental degradation and the possibility of material regeneration (Okafor, 2022). This shift is in accord with international discussions of eco-aesthetics, climate justice, and material ethics in art. Mokgosi and Enwezor (2017) contend that ecologically minded art needs to move beyond representation to engage sustainable processes and ethical

material practices. Nigerian wood sculptors are therefore placing themselves within an international, transnational discussion that interrogates the environmental impact of art production and consumption. In this manner, the revival of wood is more than a nod to heritage. It is an expression of responsibility. Materiality itself is repositioned as a site of activism, wherein the choice of wood conveys not only cultural identity but also environmental commitment. Wood, in this manner, is both medium and message: a symbol of renewal, responsibility, and resilience.

Indigenous Knowledge and Postcolonial Autonomy

The resurgence of wood in contemporary Nigerian sculpture addresses more than a choice of material. It announces an intellectual and cultural reclamation on a broader level within the postcolonial African art discourse. There has been, in recent years, an irreversible turn towards decolonizing artistic practice, whereby artists reject Euro-American models that long cast indigenous African materials and aesthetics as inferior or static (Aniakor, 2020; Eze, 2022). The use of wood, a material inextricably bound with Nigeria's spiritual, artistic, and communal past embodies this turn, offering a conduit for the reclamation of narrative agency and creative ownership.

Artists working in wood today are not replicating tradition in the folkloric sense. Instead, they are activating it as a form of epistemic resistance, which is a challenge to colonial frameworks that trapped African art within ethnographic genres. As Onwuegbule (2021) would contend, this aligns with the principles of "critical indigenism," a methodology that foregrounds indigenous knowledge systems not for preservation alone, but as living wellsprings of innovation and critique. Artists like Chukwuma and Okafor reframed wood in ways that thwart essentialist interpretation, imbuing it with contemporary urgency and postcolonial agency. It argues that African artists have the ability to define modernity on their own terms, using localized vocabularies and forms. The intentional use of wood is thus a declaration of independence, separate from Western institutional expectations but also from local pressure to conform to globalized ideals of beauty. It also bears witness to a heightened sensitivity to the entanglement of materiality, memory, and meaning within African creative knowledge systems (Okeke-Agulu, 1998). The turn to wood is thus not a step back into the past but a revolutionary, forward-looking move. It is a case of a re-appropriation of content and of intellectual autonomy in the contemporary Nigerian sculptural arena.

Conclusion

The re-emergence of wood in modern Nigerian sculpture marks a point of inflection in the development of Nigeria's visual arts. The renewed engagement with the medium is beyond the level of aesthetic revival; it is indicative of a more fundamental re-examination of artistic values, historical discourses, and socio-political roles. In re-claiming wood, a material long at the centre of Nigerian and African cultural production, artists are breaking down binaries of the traditional and the contemporary, the indigenous authentic and the globally relevant. The revival of wood usage, far from being a nostalgic embrace of cultural heritage, is a move of progressive retooling. The trend manifests as a conscious decision on the part of artists to confront a material of such profound material, symbolic, and ethical value in the 21st century. With renewed ways, conceptual layering, and increased sensitivity to the environment, Nigerian sculptors have turned wood into a site of resistance, sustainability, and self-determination. As they address issues of postcolonial identity, environmental crisis, and collective memory, artists such as Gerald Chukwuma, Amarachi Okafor, and others show how traditional materials can be used to advance critical discussion and enable artistic innovation. The revival here points to a deeper shift in the position of African art within global discourses on art. By choosing wood as medium and philosophical foundation, Nigerian artists reverse Eurocentric hierarchies of materiality and legitimize indigenous epistemologies. They argue that modernity in African art does not require imitating Western trajectories but can be produced organically from within local tradition, filtered through modern conditions. In short, the return to wood is not a passive comeback but an active, strategic re-engagement with the past, nature, and identity. This landscape expands the intellectual and material frontiers of Nigerian sculpture, securing the ongoing validity of local materials in the constantly changing landscape of international contemporary art.

Declaration

I hereby declare that this paper entitled "Resurgence of wood in contemporary Nigerian sculpture" is an original work carried out by me. All sources of information used in this study have been duly acknowledged through proper citation and referencing in accordance with academic standards.

This paper has not been submitted, either wholly or in part, for the award of any degree, diploma, or certificate in this or any other institution. I take full

responsibility for the accuracy, authenticity, and integrity of the content presented herein.

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